

Cover story **CRICKET**

the NCP's Jayant Patil, gave the go-ahead, the Congress chief minister, Ashok Chavan, refused to play ball. According to a BCCI source, an angry Pawar later told the Cricket Board that "initially Chavan too had said yes but later a phone call from Delhi made him change his mind". Chavan, however, brandishes a letter from Suprakash Chakravarty, the DGP-rank officer in-charge of poll security expressing apprehensions. Incidentally this contradicts the Mumbai Police Commissioner Hasan Gafoor who had given the go-ahead for the games. Pawar made his displeasure with his alliance partner known. He called on Amar Singh, offering to campaign for SP candidates in Uttar Pradesh, a direct snub to the Congress which is taking on the SP in the state. As election rhetoric heats up, along with the other issues being bandied about, there is now one more: IPL-2.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora and Priya Sehgal

WILL THE LOGISTICS BE A NIGHTMARE?

Could be, but Cricket South Africa (CSA) is a well-oiled organisational machine. It hosted 14 teams for six weeks during the 2003 World Cup followed by the World T-20 in 2007. CSA now has a 25-day turn-around to pull off a 59-match, six-week event. The day after the IPL moved to South Africa, multiple meetings—fixtures, transport, accommodation, security—broke out in the CSA's headquarters. A CSA staffer says there is, "no time even to be sh*****g in our pants". Yet, the IPL is a stretch worth undertaking, because South Africans believe they could earn as much as R100 million (US \$10 million) from the IPL.

The BCCI has already sanctioned a sum of \$10 million (Rs 50 crore) from its IPL account to help the offshore move along. Franchisees know the overseas IPL will cover costs like the 'staging fee' paid to a venue of a home game, Rs 50 lakh per match. A BCCI official also said the Board could bear the cost of air fare of cricketers and support staff to South Africa. A moving army of organisers, teams staff and sponsors totalling between 350 to 500 people will be leaving India soon. Jeet Banerjee, adviser, Kolkata Knight Riders says, "Think of it in terms of eight Indian teams going to a World Cup—that's what this IPL is going to be like."

Modi called the IPL "probably the single largest logistic tournament in the world in any



**LACKING LOCAL CROWD
SUPPORT, THE IPL FACES
NEWER CHALLENGES**

sport". Maybe he said 'probably' because he remembered that little event called the Olympics where athletes last numbered 10,500. The IPL, Modi says, will consume 30,000 hotel rooms and 10,000 flights. (It was 20,000 tickets last year but perhaps the number of free-loaders will be severely slashed).

Teams outside the main air transport hubs of Johannesburg, Cape Town and Durban could yet earn the kind of air miles that the Chandigarh-based Kings XI Punjab did last season. The Kings XI team needed 21 flights for their seven away games, using a total of approximately 483 air tickets.

Franchisees will run an organisational ultramarathon in the next 25 days. Passports, visas and the eternal problem: what to wear? Teams were kitted out to play in Indian summer temperatures of 35-45°C but now will play on South African autumn evenings with chilly winds and hints of the arriving winter. Inside two weeks, teams must have jackets, headgear, thicker vests and training trousers ready. A weary franchise executive says, "If we have to put player numbers on the back of the jackets by hand, then we'll do it."

The hurdle that drove the event westwards—security—is on every South Africa cricket organiser's list of high priorities. IPL security advisers Nicholls & Steyn are South



I love playing in India. As a player, you don't often get a chance to play in front of big crowds of 40,000 to 50,000 people. ♣ ♣

ANDREW FLINTOFF,
Chennai Super Kings